DEGUANG LI

PhD Researcher in History
Newnham College, University of Cambridge
dl736@cam.ac.uk · deguang99.github.io

RESEARCH PROFILE

Third-year PhD researcher at the University of Cambridge specialising in the cultural and intellectual history of knowledge and science in eighteenth- and nineteenth-century Europe, particularly Britain and France. My doctoral research examines the observation, circulation, and contestation of astronomical knowledge in London and Paris through the Great Comet of 1811. Wider interests include environmental history, print and material culture, scientific instruments, and the social and geographical settings of knowledge-making.

EDUCATION

2024–present — PhD in History, Faculty of History, University of Cambridge
Dissertation: "Re-enchantment of the Comet in Paris and London, 1811–1812"
Expected submission: June 2027
Supervisors: Alexandra Walsham and Emma Spary (continuing); advisor: Joshua Nall

2021–2024 — MPhil in Intellectual History, Department of History, Tsinghua University
Thesis: "Theatre in May '68: Antigone as Myth, History, and Ritual"
Supervisor: Peng Gang
GPA: 4.0/4.0

Jan–Jun 2020 — Exchange Studies, Sciences Po, Paris
GPA: 16/20 (a grade of 16 or higher is considered to be superior work)

2017–2021 — BA in Comparative Literature, Tsinghua University
World Literature and Culture Programme (Xuetang Talents Programme)
GPA: 3.89/4.0

PUBLICATIONS AND SCHOLARLY WORK

ACCEPTED / FORTHCOMING

"From Gentleman's Observatory to Women's College: The Transnational Life of the Newnham Telescope." *Bulletin of the Scientific Instrument Society*, no. 171 (December 2026), 23–28.

REVISION INVITED AFTER PEER REVIEW

"The Making of Superstition: Metropolitan Serial Print and the Ordering of Cometary Knowledge in London, 1811." *The British Journal for the History of Science*. Revision invited after peer review.

UNDER REVIEW

"A Comet Cannot Become a Sun: Celestial Knowledge and Political Culture in Napoleonic France." *French History*. Under review.

"Retail China: Chineseness, Commodity Knowledge, and the British Trade Card, 1750–1830." *Journal for Eighteenth-Century Studies*. Under review.

CONTRACTED WORK

"Répétition: Antigone and the Making of Revolutionary Context in Avignon, 1968." Chapter for *Context* (Peter Lang); under contract, planned 2027.

Dominick LaCapra, *History and Criticism* (Cornell University Press, 1985). Chinese translation, Commercial Press (商务印书馆); under contract, manuscript submitted, planned 2027.

RESEARCH DATASETS

Li, Deguang. 2026. The Great Comet of 1811 in Metropolitan Serial Print: A Bibliographical Corpus, 1811–1812. Version 1.0. Zenodo. https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.24146584

SELECTED CONFERENCE PAPERS AND TALKS

Sep 2026	International Society for Intellectual History (ISIH), Istanbul *"(Dis-)Ordering the Heavens, Ordering the Polity: Cometary Knowledge and Political Culture in Napoleonic France."*
Jul 2026	ESHS/HSS Joint Conference, Edinburgh *"The Making of Superstition: Metropolitan Serial Print and the Ordering of Cometary Knowledge in London, 1811–1812."*
Mar 2026	"Cities" Symposium, University of Cambridge *"Mapping the Heavens in the City: Cometary Knowledge and Urban Geographies in London and Paris, 1811–1812."*
Nov 2025	Newnham History Forum, University of Cambridge (keynote) *"Before Newnham: The Transnational Craft, Local Practice, and Women's Scientific Engagement of a Nineteenth-Century Telescope."*
Jun 2025	Newnham Graduate Conference, University of Cambridge *"Re-enchantment of the Comet in Paris and London, 1811–1812: On the Uncertainty of Enlightenment."*
May 2025	IHR British History in the Long Eighteenth Century Seminar *"Re-enchantment of the Comet in Paris and London, 1811–1812."*
Apr 2025	Cambridge French Graduate Conference *"Répétition: Contextualising Antigone in Mai '68."*
Mar 2025	PhD Presentation Day, University of Cambridge *"Re-enchantment of the Comet in Paris and London, 1811–1812."*
Nov 2024	Material Culture Forum, University of Cambridge *"From Telescopes to Teapots: The Role of Material Culture in Shaping Responses to the Great Comet of 1811."*

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

2026–2027	Supervisor, HPS Part II Paper 1: Early Science and Medicine, University of Cambridge

ACADEMIC ROLES AND SERVICE

2025–present	Transcription Project Assistant (volunteer), Whipple Museum of the History of Science, Cambridge
2025–present	Editor, *Doing History in Public,* University of Cambridge
2024–present	Junior Fellow, Institute for World Literatures and Cultures, Tsinghua University
2023–2024	Secretariat Assistant, UK–China Humanities Alliance
2023–2024	Office Assistant, Institute for World Literatures and Cultures, Tsinghua University

SELECTED GRANTS AND HONOURS

2026	Lisa Jardine Grant, Royal Society
2026	Research Support Grant, Royal Historical Society
2025	Postgraduate Research & Travel Grants, Newnham College
2025	Fieldwork Fund, Faculty of History, University of Cambridge
2025	Postgraduate Research Grant, Society for the Study of French History
2022	Dean's Scholarship, School of Humanities, Tsinghua University
2022	Guang Gu Scholarship (First Class), Tsinghua University
2017	Tsinghua Academy Scholarship for Undergraduates

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE AND METHODS

Archival research across more than twenty repositories in Britain and France, working with manuscript, printed, visual, and material sources. Scientific instrument and collection research through the Whipple Museum of the History of Science and the Museum of Archaeology and Anthropology, Cambridge. Digital methods include structured source databases, historical georeferencing, GIS mapping, and spatial analysis.

LANGUAGES AND AFFILIATIONS

Mandarin Chinese (native); English (fluent); French (working proficiency); Italian (beginner).

Postgraduate member, Royal Historical Society (since 2024);

Member, British Society for the History of Science (since 2024);

Member, Society for the Study of French History (since 2024).